Haul

github.com/Gabriel-Castiglia/haul

Gabriel Castiglia · October 24, 2026 · version 1.3.0 · GPL-2.0 license · built and tested with yt-dlp 2026.08.19

English · Español

Repository: https://github.com/Gabriel-Castiglia/haul

Windows version: https://github.com/Gabriel-Castiglia/haul-windows

PDF manual: `docs/Haul-manual-en.pdf`

Haul is a macOS app that works as a front end for yt-dlp. The app builds the command, shows the progress and manages a download queue. The actual work is done by yt-dlp, bundled with the app at a fixed, verified version, and by ffmpeg, installed with Homebrew. The interface is available in English and Spanish, selectable from the Language menu; it starts in English on first launch and remembers the choice. The window is always dark, whatever the system appearance.

Requirements

- macOS 15 or later, on a Mac with Apple silicon. Tested on macOS 27.
- Homebrew in `/opt/homebrew`.
- Apple's Command Line Tools (`xcode-select --install`). Xcode is not needed.

yt-dlp ships with the app. Python, deno and ffmpeg are installed by the installer, so nothing has to be installed by hand.

Installation

```
git clone https://github.com/Gabriel-Castiglia/haul.git
cd haul
scripts/instalar.sh
```

The installer:

1. installs Python, deno and ffmpeg with Homebrew or, if they are already present, upgrades them;
2. builds the app, checks the bundled yt-dlp against its official checksums, and signs the app with the local identity (see "Signing and permissions");
3. copies it to `/Applications/Haul.app`, quitting it first if it is running.

Running it again is how everything gets updated, dependencies and app alike.

Usage

1. Paste one or more links into the box at the top. Links can be pasted on their own, one per line, or inside text copied from somewhere else; the app extracts them and drops duplicates. If clipboard access is allowed, the app picks up a copied link by itself when it opens.
2. Choose the format: Video (MP4) or Audio only (MP3).
3. Choose the destination folder. The first time it is Downloads; after that the app keeps the last folder chosen, and the format too.
4. Press Download or ⌘↩. The box empties when the download starts, and a link already in the queue is not picked up again from the clipboard.

Links go into a queue and are downloaded one at a time. More links can be added while the queue runs. Each row shows the thumbnail, title, percentage, speed and time remaining, and once finished it offers to reveal the file in the Finder or open it. Failed or cancelled downloads can be retried or removed. A cancelled download deletes the partial files it had created; files that were already in the folder, such as an earlier download of the same video in another format, are never touched. The full yt-dlp output is under "Technical details".

A download that fails is tried again up to four times, two seconds apart, and the row shows which attempt is running ("Retry 2/4"). Partial files are kept between attempts, so yt-dlp resumes where it stopped. When a download finishes, the app also deletes the intermediate files yt-dlp could not remove by itself, such as the original audio of an MP3 while a file sync client held it open.

The "Clear finished automatically" checkbox, below the format, is always in view, even with an empty queue. While it is checked, every download that finishes or is cancelled leaves the list by itself, and the summary keeps counting it; failed ones stay, so they can be retried. Checking it also clears what had already finished. The app remembers the setting.

Videos with "instrumental" in the title wait in the queue, paused, unless "Download instrumentals" is checked. A paused row can be downloaded on its own with its download button, and checking the option resumes all of them.

The ⓘ button in the window, or Haul > About Haul in the menu bar, shows the version, the meaning of the name, the author, the license and the link to this repository, in the interface language. The header with that button stays fixed at the top of the window, and the rest scrolls under it.

The app can also be started with links from Terminal or from Shortcuts:

```
open -a Haul --args --descargar URL1 URL2
```

Formats

Format	Result	yt-dlp options
Video	MP4 with H.264 and AAC, at the highest resolution available in H.264	`-f bv*+ba/b -S vcodec:h264,res,acodec:aac --merge-output-format mp4`
Audio only	MP3 at the highest quality	`-x --audio-format mp3 --audio-quality 0`

H.264 is preferred because QuickTime and iOS play it without conversion. Files are named after the video title.

Playlists

A playlist link or a channel page is read first, without downloading anything, and every video becomes its own row in the queue, with its thumbnail and its position ("Mix · 3/12"). The files go into a subfolder named after the playlist and are numbered in playlist order: `01 – Title.mp4`, `02 – Title.mp4`, and so on. Each video can be cancelled or retried on its own. A playlist with more than 200 videos asks for confirmation first.

A link to a video that was opened from a playlist shows a card in the window that asks whether to download only that video or the whole playlist. Other links download as they are, one video each.

Some tag pages that group several posts, each with an embedded video, are read the same way: one row per post, from the oldest to the newest, so a series keeps its episode order.

Repository layout

Path	Contents
`fuentes/Haul.swift`	App source code (SwiftUI, a single file)
`icono/icono.html`	Icon as SVG
`icono/icono-1024.png`	Rendered icon, source for every size
`scripts/instalar.sh`	Dependencies, build and installation
`scripts/compilar.sh`	Build and signing into `build/`
`scripts/firma.sh`	Local signing identity (sourced by `compilar.sh`)
`scripts/manual.sh`	Builds the PDF manuals from the READMEs
`scripts/actualizar-yt-dlp.sh`	Replaces the bundled yt-dlp with another verified release
`plugins/haul/`	Haul's own yt-dlp extractor plugin, for links the bundled version does not handle
`vendor/yt-dlp/`	Bundled copy of yt-dlp 2026.08.19, with sources, checksums, signature and licenses
`docs/Haul-manual-en.pdf`, `docs/Haul-manual-es.pdf`	PDF manuals, in English and Spanish
`docs/manual.css`	Stylesheet for the manuals
`README.md`, `README.es.md`	This documentation, in English and Spanish

The `build/` folder is generated at build time and is not part of the repository.

Signing and permissions

macOS stores the permissions a user grants, such as access to Downloads or to the clipboard, together with the app's signature. An ad hoc signature changes on every build, so macOS asks for them again. That is why the project signs with its own stable certificate, "Haul (local signing)", which `scripts/firma.sh` creates the first time on the Mac where the app is built:

- the certificate and its key live in a dedicated keychain, `~/Library/Keychains/haul-signing.keychain-db`;
- that keychain's password lives in the login keychain, under the name `haul-local-signing`.

With that signature, permissions granted once are kept across versions. The certificate exists only on the Mac where it was created: a built copy taken to another Mac must be opened the first time with right-click and Open.

Automatic pasting of links when the app opens works only if clipboard access is set to "Always Allow" (System Settings, Privacy & Security, Paste from Other Apps). Without that permission the app reads the clipboard only when Paste is pressed, and shows no prompt when it opens.

Icon

The interface takes the system accent color and follows it when it changes. The icon, on the other hand, is fixed (graphite with the current accent green), because an icon that adapts to the system theme requires the Icon Composer format and Xcode. To change its colors, edit the `stop-color` values in `icono/icono.html`, render the PNG again and reinstall:

```
"/Applications/Google Chrome.app/Contents/MacOS/Google Chrome" --headless --hide-scro
llbars \
  --force-device-scale-factor=2 --window-size=512,512 --default-background-color=0000
0000 \
  --screenshot="$PWD/icono/icono-1024.png" "file://$PWD/icono/icono.html"
scripts/instalar.sh
```

If the Dock keeps showing the old icon, remove the app from the Dock and add it again.

Maintenance

Haul is built and tested with yt-dlp 2026.08.19, and that exact copy ships inside the app. A pinned version keeps the behavior stable and does not depend on the yt-dlp repository staying online. The trade-off is that sites change often, and sooner or later a fixed version stops working with them. When that happens, a new release of Haul moves to a newer yt-dlp:

```
scripts/actualizar-yt-dlp.sh <version>
scripts/instalar.sh
```

The first script downloads the release, verifies its signature with the key stored in `vendor/yt-dlp/public.key` and its SHA-256 checksums, and only then replaces the files. Running `scripts/instalar.sh` again also upgrades Python, deno and ffmpeg.

The most common yt-dlp errors are shown in plain words in the interface language (video unavailable, private video, unsupported site, no connection); anything else appears exactly as yt-dlp prints it.

Preferences (language, folder, format, window size, "Clear finished automatically" and "Download instrumentals") are stored in the `io.github.gabriel-castiglia.haul` domain. They can be reset with `defaults delete io.github.gabriel-castiglia.haul`.

Technical notes

The app runs the bundled yt-dlp with Homebrew's Python as a child process and adds `/opt/homebrew/bin` to `PATH`, because an app launched from the Finder does not inherit the Terminal's and would not find deno or ffmpeg. To avoid depending on the text yt-dlp prints for the Terminal, it asks for output in a custom, tab-separated format:

Line	Contents	Source
`META`	id, channel, uploader, title and thumbnail, checked before downloading	`-O pre_process:…`
`INFO`	title, uploader, duration, thumbnail and file name	`-O before_dl:…`
`AVANCE`	percentage, speed and time remaining	`--progress-template`
`ARCHIVO`	final file path	`-O after_move:…`

Paused instrumentals are held back with `--match-filters`, so yt-dlp downloads nothing until they are allowed.

Some links fail inside yt-dlp itself, its latest release included: a video page that now asks for an account although its embedded player does not, and pages whose data moved to a different place. Haul ships a yt-dlp extractor plugin of its own in `plugins/haul/`, copied into `Contents/Resources/plugins` and passed with `--plugin-dirs`. Plugin extractors are tried before the built-in ones, and each one only matches the links it fixes. When the embedded player answers with an occasional 401 error, the plugin retries up to three times. Python runs with `PYTHONDONTWRITEBYTECODE=1` so it does not write `__pycache__` inside the signed app.

Building without Xcode imposes two limitations, both handled in the code. First, SwiftUI's `@State` macro is unavailable, because its plugin ships only with Xcode; the code uses `@StateObject` with the `Marca` class instead. Second, with a hidden title bar SwiftUI ignores `.defaultSize`, so the initial window size is set through AppKit in `applicationDidFinishLaunching`.

Credits

Haul is a front end; the hard work belongs to these projects:

Project	Role in Haul	License
yt-dlp, by the yt-dlp contributors, fork of youtube-dl	Download engine, bundled in `vendor/yt-dlp`	Unlicense
yt-dlp-ejs, included in the yt-dlp executable	JavaScript challenge solver	Unlicense
meriyah, by KFlash and others, inside yt-dlp-ejs	JavaScript parser	ISC
astring, by David Bonnet, inside yt-dlp-ejs	JavaScript code generator	MIT
FFmpeg, installed with Homebrew, not bundled	Merges picture and sound, converts to MP3	LGPL-2.1+ / GPL-2.0+, depending on the build
Deno, installed with Homebrew	JavaScript runtime used by yt-dlp	MIT
Python, installed with Homebrew	Runs yt-dlp	PSF License
Homebrew	Installs the dependencies	BSD-2-Clause
pandoc, only to build the PDF manuals	Markdown to HTML conversion	GPL-2.0+

The license texts of the bundled components are in `vendor/yt-dlp/licenses/` and are copied into the app, under `Contents/Resources/licenses/`.

License

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Haul includes an unmodified copy of yt-dlp in `vendor/yt-dlp`, which keeps its own licenses (Unlicense, with ISC and MIT components) and is not covered by the GPL. Haul runs yt-dlp and ffmpeg as separate programs and does not link to them; ffmpeg is not bundled.